

BEFORE YOU LAND™

The Complete Packing Checklist

What to bring, what to buy in America, and what customs will take from you at the airport — sorted by suitcase.



Created by **Nii Obodai** × **Travedconsult.com**

[SURVIVAL KIT BONUS · PRINT ME](#)

The three laws of packing

- 1 **Documents and medicine are irreplaceable. Almost everything else is a store away.** Pack accordingly: paperwork gets first-class treatment; towels do not fly internationally.
- 2 **Your carry-on must be able to survive alone.** Checked bags get delayed. If yours vanished for three days, your carry-on should still contain your documents, meds, valuables, chargers, and one change of clothes.
- 3 **When in doubt, leave it out.** The most common packing regret is not "I forgot X" — it's "why did I bring all this?" America sells things. Save the kilos for what America can't sell you: your documents, your medicines, and the taste of home.

BAG 1 • CARRY-ON

The survival bag — never leaves your side

The documents folder ▲

- ☐ Passport (with visa) + I-20 / DS-2019 — **on your body, never in checked luggage**
- ☐ SEVIS I-901 fee receipt
- ☐ Admission / offer letter
- ☐ Proof of funds (bank statements / sponsor letter)
- ☐ Health insurance card or confirmation
- ☐ Vaccination records & medical history, in English
- ☐ Official transcripts & degree certificates (sealed copies if your school requires)
- ☐ Prescriptions with doctor's letter (generic drug names)
- ☐ Passport photos (a few spares — useful for IDs and forms)
- ☐ Photocopy set + everything scanned to cloud storage
- ☐ Address of where you're sleeping tonight, written down

Also in the carry-on

- ☐ Medicines for the journey + first two weeks (rest can ride in checked bag)
- ☐ Laptop, phone, chargers, power bank (power banks *must* go carry-on, not checked)
- ☐ One plug adapter (US: Type A/B, 120V) — check if your devices are dual-voltage
- ☐ One full change of clothes + light sweater (planes and airports are cold)
- ☐ Cash in US dollars — mostly small bills — and your international card

- ☐ Glasses / contacts + a copy of your prescription
- ☐ Pen (for any forms), empty water bottle, snacks for the journey
- ☐ House/luggage keys, headphones, and something to make 14 hours bearable

BAG 2 · CHECKED LUGGAGE

The life bag

Clothing — think capsule, not closet

- ☐ 1–2 weeks of everyday clothes you actually wear (the test: did you wear it last month?)
- ☐ One formal/professional outfit — presentations, career fairs, interviews come faster than you think
- ☐ Traditional attire from home — for cultural events, international nights, and photos you'll treasure
- ☐ Comfortable walking shoes (broken in), one formal pair, sandals/slides
- ☐ Light jacket + one warm layer to land with
buy the serious winter coat in America — better quality, better prices, less suitcase space (Guide Ch. 13)
- ☐ Underwear & socks for two weeks, sleepwear, gym clothes, swimwear
- ☐ Modest laundry bag — laundry day arrives fast

Health & personal

- ☐ Remaining 90-day supply of prescription meds, original packaging
- ☐ Small familiar-brands kit: pain reliever, cold medicine, plasters — comfort of the known while you learn US brands
- ☐ Toiletries for the first week only (all liquids over 100ml go here, not carry-on)
- ☐ Hair care and skin care from home if your products are hard to find abroad — ask seniors from your country what's available
- ☐ Spare glasses/contacts if you use them

The taste of home

- ☐ Spices and spice blends (sealed, commercially packaged travels best)
- ☐ Tea/coffee from home, packaged snacks and sweets to share
- ☐ Your one sentimental cooking tool, if you cook
the pot can be bought; the recipe memory can't
- ☐ Small gifts from home for new friends and hosts — inexpensive, meaningful, brilliant icebreakers
- ☐ Photos of family/friends (printed), one small object that makes any room feel like yours

FOOD & CUSTOMS: KNOW BEFORE YOU PACK

U.S. customs is strict about agriculture. Generally risky or banned: fresh fruits & vegetables, meat and meat products (including dried/cured — yes, that too), fresh dairy, seeds, soil, and plants. Generally fine: commercially sealed spices, tea, packaged dry snacks. Rules change — check the official CBP list before flying, and **declare all food on your customs form**. Declaring something banned costs you the item; hiding it can cost you a fine and a very bad day.

ELECTRONICS & EXTRAS

The tech kit

- ☐ Phone (confirmed unlocked!) + spare old phone if you have one
- ☐ Laptop + charger (buying new? U.S. student discounts are often better — compare first)
- ☐ 2–3 plug adapters, or one adapter + a power strip from home (one adapter powers all your devices)
- ☐ USB drive / hard drive with backed-up documents and photos
- ☐ Cables, earphones, and any device you genuinely use weekly

VOLTAGE CHECK, 10 SECONDS

Look at the fine print on your charger: if it says "**100–240V**" you only need a cheap plug adapter. If it says 220–240V only (common for hair dryers, kettles, irons), it will die dramatically on U.S. 120V — leave it home and buy there.

THE OTHER LIST

Do NOT pack

- **Banned/risky at customs:** fresh produce, meat products (yes, including the dried kind hidden in the shoe), fresh dairy, seeds, soil, counterfeit goods
- **Not in checked bags (airline rules):** power banks and spare lithium batteries — carry-on only
- **Wrong-voltage appliances:** hair dryers, kettles, irons, rice cookers — a new one costs less than the adapter to save it
- **Bedding & towels** — bulky, cheap to buy on arrival, first shopping trip anyway
- **A year of toiletries** — one week's worth; America has stores and they are enormous
- **Every book you love** — heaviest items per kilo of joy; bring one or two, ship or digitize the rest
- **Large amounts of cash** — carry a sensible amount; anything over \$10,000 must be declared (Guide Ch. 3)
- **Anything you'd cry to lose** in a checked bag — valuables ride carry-on or stay home

SAVE THE KILOS

Buy it in America instead

- Winter coat, boots & serious cold gear
- Bedding, pillows, towels
- Kitchen pots, pans & utensils
- Bulk toiletries & cleaning supplies
- Desk lamp, hangers, storage bins
- Umbrella (the airport one breaks anyway)
- Stationery & school supplies
- Printer paper, notebooks
- Basic tools & extension cords
- Most furniture-adjacent anything

Pro move: secondhand stores, campus "free & for sale" groups, and graduating students selling everything each May and December. Your entire room can be furnished for very little — Guide Ch. 12 has the money habits to match.

Stay connected

Created by **Nii Obodai** — say hello, ask your questions, and tag me when you land. I read everything.

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